“Christians will judge me.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Many people have experienced a cold look, a gossip circle, or a sermon that felt like a finger pointing at them. Some of us were judged for divorce, doubt, addiction, appearance, or politics. After that, it feels safer to expect judgment from every believer than to risk it again.

What Scripture teaches

Jesus said, “Do not judge, or you will be judged,” and warned believers about the measure they use. When the woman caught in adultery stood before Him, He asked, “Woman, where are your accusers? Has no one condemned you?” Then He said, “neither do I condemn you.” James writes, “Mercy triumphs over judgment.” Paul adds that “there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus.” Some Christians fail to reflect Jesus, but He does not fail to reflect Himself. The Savior who welcomed sinners is the standard, not the critics.

> *“Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus”* (Romans 8:1).

Also see

> “‘Do not judge, or you will be judged. For with the same judgment you pronounce, you will be judged; and with the measure you use, it will be measured to you.’” (Matthew 7:1–2).

> “Then Jesus straightened up and asked her, ‘Woman, where are your accusers? Has no one condemned you?’ ‘No one, Lord,’ she answered. ‘Then neither do I condemn you,’ Jesus declared. ‘Now go and sin no more.’” (John 8:10–11).

> “For judgment without mercy will be shown to anyone who has not been merciful. Mercy triumphs over judgment” (James 2:13).

> “Brothers, if someone is caught in a trespass, you who are spiritual should restore him with a spirit of gentleness. But watch yourself, or you also may be tempted” (Galatians 6:1).

Common self-statements

- They will look down on me.
- Church people are hypocrites.
- If they knew, they would condemn me.
- I will be talked about.
- I do not meet their standards.
- It is safer to stay away.

Common logical errors

- Overgeneralizing: Treating all Christians as judges because of some.
- Mind reading: Assuming I know what they think.
- Fortune telling: Predicting condemnation before it happens.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling judged and concluding that I am.

Challenging questions

- Who judged me, and what exactly did they do or say?
- Have any Christians shown me grace?
- How did Jesus treat people others judged?
- Is judgment by some people a reason to avoid all people?
- What would a gracious community look like?
- Is there one safe person I could try again with?

Truth summary

> Jesus does not condemn me, and He calls His people to mercy, not judgment. Some Christians fall short of that, but I can look for those who reflect His grace. I do not have to let past judgment keep me from the fellowship God offers.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Judgmental
- Hypocritical
- Church
- Mercy
- Forgiveness

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Judgmental
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Christ bears the burden of rescue rather than demanding self-salvation.

Forgiveness — Matthew West
Ask God for help releasing resentment while working through real hurt.

Clean — Natalie Grant
God's cleansing grace challenges the belief that shame or sin makes a person beyond restoration.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Christians will judge me"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Christians will judge me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who judged me?
- ☐ What did they say?
- ☐ Who has shown me grace?
- ☐ How did Jesus treat the judged?
- ☐ What would a gracious church look like?
- ☐ Who is one safe person?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ There is no condemnation in Christ.
- ☐ Mercy triumphs over judgment.
- ☐ Jesus welcomed sinners.
- ☐ Judgment by some does not define all.
- ☐ Grace-filled Christians exist.
- ☐ I can find a safe community.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Romans 8:1
  "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."
- ☐ John 8:10–11
  "Then Jesus straightened up and asked her, 'Woman, where are your accusers? Has no one condemned you?' 'No one, Lord,' she answered. 'Then neither do I condemn you,' Jesus declared. 'Now go and sin no more.'"
- ☐ James 2:13
  "For judgment without mercy will be shown to anyone who has not been merciful. Mercy triumphs over judgment."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Grace seen: Each week, write one example of grace shown by a believer.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Romans 8:1 becomes: "Sarah can write: "There is no condemnation for me in Christ Jesus.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Judgmental" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Tell the story. Write what happened and how it made you feel.
- ☐ Read John 8:1–11. Notice how Jesus treated the accused.
- ☐ Look for grace. Find one believer who shows mercy and spend time with them.
- ☐ Forgive as you can. Pray for the people who judged you.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Christians will judge me": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Grace seen
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Christians will judge me.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord Jesus, You did not condemn the woman, and You do not condemn me. Heal the hurt from judgment and lead me to Your people who show mercy. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

“Everyone at church has it all together but me.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

On Sunday morning people arrive in nice clothes, smiling, with children in order and answers ready. We see their best and compare it with our worst. Church culture can also reward looking fine, so struggles stay hidden and everyone concludes that they alone are failing.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes plainly, “All have sinned and fall short of the glory of God,” and John says, “If we say we have no sin, we deceive ourselves, and the truth is not in us.” Paul also says, “We have this treasure in jars of clay to show that this surpassingly great power is from God and not from us.” Jesus said, “It is not the healthy who need a doctor, but the sick.” The church is not a gathering of finished people. It is a gathering of forgiven people who are still being changed, and many of them are hurting more than they show.

> *“For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God”* (Romans 3:23).

Also see

> “If we say we have no sin, we deceive ourselves, and the truth is not in us” (1 John 1:8).

> “Now we have this treasure in jars of clay to show that this surpassingly great power is from God and not from us” (2 Corinthians 4:7).

> “Therefore confess your sins to each other and pray for each other so that you may be healed. The prayer of a righteous man has great power to prevail” (James 5:16).

> “Jesus answered, ‘It is not the healthy who need a doctor, but the sick.’” (Luke 5:31).

Common self-statements

- They have no problems.
- I am the only one who is struggling.
- Everyone else is more spiritual.
- If I show my struggles, I will not belong.
- I must be failing as a Christian.
- Their lives are perfect.

Common logical errors

- Social comparison: Comparing my private struggles with their public image.
- Mind reading: Assuming that they have no problems.
- Mental filter: Focusing on what looks good and missing hidden pain.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling inadequate and concluding that I am.

Challenging questions

- How much do I actually know about the lives of people at church?
- What do I show to others at church, and what do I hide?
- If someone else hid struggles as I do, what would that mean about them?

- What does Scripture say about the condition of all believers?
- What would happen if one person were honest?
- Who might also be struggling and need to hear that I am?

Truth summary

> No one at church has it all together. We are all forgiven sinners, treasures in jars of clay. My struggles do not disqualify me, and honesty can free others as well as myself.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Hypocritical
- Church
- Pride
- Confession
- Self-Esteem, Low

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Pride

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Broken Things — Matthew West
God can work through imperfect people without waiting for them to become flawless.

Worn — Tenth Avenue North
Weariness can be expressed honestly while asking God for restoration.

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Christ bears the burden of rescue rather than demanding self-salvation.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Everyone at church has it all together but me"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Everyone at church has it all together but me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What do I hide at church?
- ☐ What do I really know about them?
- ☐ Who might be struggling too?
- ☐ What does Scripture say about all of us?
- ☐ Who can I be honest with?
- ☐ What would honesty do?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ All have sinned, including those who look fine.
- ☐ The church is for the sick, not the perfect.
- ☐ We are jars of clay.
- ☐ Honesty invites healing.
- ☐ My struggle is common.
- ☐ I belong among imperfect people.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Romans 3:23
  "For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God."
- ☐ 2 Corinthians 4:7
  "Now we have this treasure in jars of clay to show that this surpassingly great power is from God and not from us."
- ☐ Luke 5:31
  "Jesus answered, 'It is not the healthy who need a doctor, but the sick.'"

A verse I found myself: _____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Honesty and welcome: Each week, note one moment of honesty at church and how it was received.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Romans 3:23 becomes: "Sarah can write: "All of us fall short, and Christ welcomes all of us.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Church" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Ask yourself what is hidden. List what you hide at church and why.
- ☐ Share a small struggle. Tell one trusted believer something real.
- ☐ Listen for others. Ask someone "How are you really doing?"
- ☐ Read 2 Corinthians 4:7. Remember that cracks let the light through.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Everyone at church has it all together but me": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	An honest moment
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Everyone at church has it all together but me.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, I have compared my inside to everyone else's outside. Thank You that Your church is for sinners. Give me courage to be real and compassion for others who are hurting too. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

“Because church people hurt me, God must be just like them.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

When those who speak for God use that voice to control, shame, or harm, it is hard to separate them from God. A pastor’s betrayal, a youth leader’s abuse of trust, or a church’s harsh rejection can leave a child or adult convinced that God shares their coldness or cruelty.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture describes God’s own character: “The LORD, the LORD God, is compassionate and gracious, slow to anger, abounding in loving devotion and faithfulness.” “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit.” Of His servant it says, “A bruised reed He will not break and a smoldering wick He will not extinguish.” The writer of Hebrews says that Jesus, our high priest, sympathizes with our weaknesses. God never promised that every person speaking in His name reflects Him. The measure of God is Jesus, who was gentle with the wounded and angry only at those who burdened them.

> *“The LORD is compassionate and gracious, slow to anger, abounding in loving devotion”* (Psalm 103:8).

Also see

> “Then the LORD passed in front of Moses and called out: ‘The LORD, the LORD God, is compassionate and gracious, slow to anger, abounding in loving devotion and faithfulness.’” (Exodus 34:6).

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” (Psalm 34:18).

> “A bruised reed He will not break and a smoldering wick He will not extinguish; He will faithfully bring forth justice” (Isaiah 42:3).

> “For we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses, but we have one who was tempted in every way that we are, yet was without sin” (Hebrews 4:15).

Common self-statements

- If that is what Christians are like, I want nothing to do with God.
- God let them do it, so He must be like them.
- They spoke for God, so God must agree with them.
- I cannot trust God after that.
- All religion is just control.
- God is as harsh as they were.

Common logical errors

- Overgeneralizing: Letting a few people stand for God and all believers.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling betrayed and concluding God is the same.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing the church and God are either both good or both bad.
- Guilt by association: Judging God by those who claimed to represent Him.

Challenging questions

- What exactly was done to me, and who did it?
- Did those people actually reflect God's character as Scripture describes it?
- How does Jesus treat people who are hurt by religious leaders?
- Is it fair to judge God by those who misrepresented Him?
- What do I want God to be like?
- What would it look like to read the Gospels to see Jesus for myself?

Truth summary

> People who hurt me in God's name misrepresented Him. God is compassionate, gracious, and near to the brokenhearted. I can grieve what was done and take my time getting to know the real God through Jesus.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Church
- Hypocritical
- God, All Loving
- Mercy
- Child Abuse/Neglect

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Suffering
- Judgmental

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Fear Is a Liar — Zach Williams
Examine fear-driven accusations rather than treating them as reliable truth.

Truth Be Told — Matthew West featuring Carly Pearce
Honesty about struggles makes room for grace and support instead of pretending to be fine.

He Knows — Jeremy Camp
Jesus understands suffering and invites people to bring their burdens to Him.

Softly and Tenderly — Kristyn Getty with Vince Gill, Ellie Holcomb and Sierra Hull
This older hymn pictures Christ's gracious invitation to return rather than hide in shame.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Because church people hurt me, God must be just like them"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Because church people hurt me, God must be just like them." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What was done in God's name?
- ☐ How is God different from them?
- ☐ How does Jesus treat the hurt?
- ☐ Who can I get support from?
- ☐ What do I need from God?
- ☐ What can I read about Jesus?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God is compassionate and gracious.
- ☐ He is near to the brokenhearted.
- ☐ He does not break a bruised reed.
- ☐ Those who hurt me did not speak for Him.
- ☐ Jesus sympathizes with my weakness.
- ☐ I can come to God at my own pace.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 103:8
  "The LORD is compassionate and gracious, slow to anger, abounding in loving devotion."
- ☐ Psalm 34:18
  "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit."
- ☐ Isaiah 42:3
  "A bruised reed He will not break and a smoldering wick He will not extinguish; He will faithfully bring forth justice."

A verse I found myself: _____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ The real God: Each week, write one trait of God from Scripture that differs from how I was treated.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Psalm 103:8 becomes: "Sarah can write: "The Lord is compassionate and gracious, unlike those who hurt me.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "God, All Loving" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Name what happened. Write the facts of what was done in God's name.
- ☐ Get support. Tell a counselor or trusted friend; seek legal and safe help if abuse occurred.
- ☐ Read a Gospel. Read Mark slowly and note how Jesus treated hurting people.
- ☐ Pray honestly. Tell God your anger and hurt.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Because church people hurt me, God must be just like them": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	The real God
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Because church people hurt me, God must be just like them.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I was hurt by people who spoke in Your name. Show me who You really are. Heal my wounds and help me meet You through Jesus, gentle with the broken. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

“I don't belong in church because of my past.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

A history of addiction, divorce, abortion, prison, affairs, or years away from God can make a church building feel like a courtroom. We imagine that everyone has a spotless record and that our past would be unwelcome. Sometimes this is reinforced by real experiences of being whispered about.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes to the Corinthians, “And that is what some of you were. But you were washed, you were sanctified, you were justified, in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ and by the Spirit of our God.” The Pharisees grumbled, “This man welcomes sinners and eats with them,” which was a compliment, not an insult. Jesus said of the woman who anointed His feet, “because her many sins have been forgiven, she has loved much.” Paul adds, “If anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation.” Hebrews says, “Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence.” The church is where forgiven people gather, and your past is not your identity.

> *“And that is what some of you were. But you were washed, you were sanctified, you were justified, in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ and by the Spirit of our God”*
> (1 Corinthians 6:11).

Also see

> “So the Pharisees and scribes began to grumble: ‘This man welcomes sinners and eats with them.’” (Luke 15:2).

> “Therefore I tell you, because her many sins have been forgiven, she has loved much. But he who has been forgiven little loves little” (Luke 7:47).

> “Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!” (2 Corinthians 5:17).

> “Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need” (Hebrews 4:16).

Common self-statements

- People like me do not belong.
- If they knew my past, they would ask me to leave.
- I have been too far away for too long.
- I am too damaged.
- I will bring shame on the church.
- I need to clean up first.

Common logical errors

- Labeling: Calling myself by my worst moments.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that I will be rejected.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling ashamed and concluding that I do not belong.
- Discounting the positive: Ignoring that Christ has forgiven me.

Challenging questions

- What exactly in my past do I think disqualifies me?
- Has God forgiven it, according to Scripture?
- Whom did Jesus welcome?
- What would it mean to be washed and justified?
- Who in the church might understand my story?
- What would help me take one step toward a welcoming community?

Truth summary

> Christ has washed, sanctified, and justified me. My past is forgiven, and I am a new creation. I belong in the community of forgiven people, and I can look for a church that welcomes sinners as Jesus did.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Church
- Forgiveness
- Guilt/Shame
- Born Again
- Grace

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Judgmental

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Clean — Natalie Grant
God's cleansing grace challenges the belief that shame or sin makes a person beyond restoration.

Forgiveness — Matthew West
Ask God for help releasing resentment while working through real hurt.

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Christ bears the burden of rescue rather than demanding self-salvation.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "I don't belong in church because of my past"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I don't belong in church because of my past." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What in my past worries me?
- ☐ What does God say about it?
- ☐ Whom did Jesus welcome?
- ☐ What church welcomes sinners?
- ☐ Who is a safe believer?
- ☐ What is my next step?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I was washed, sanctified, and justified.
- ☐ Jesus welcomes sinners.
- ☐ I am a new creation.
- ☐ Much forgiven, I love much.
- ☐ I can approach the throne of grace.
- ☐ My past is not my identity.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ 1 Corinthians 6:11
  "And that is what some of you were. But you were washed, you were sanctified, you were justified, in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ and by the Spirit of our God."
- ☐ 2 Corinthians 5:17
  "Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!"
- ☐ Hebrews 4:16
  "Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Forgiven and welcome: Each week, record one moment of welcome or one truth about forgiveness.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 1 Corinthians 6:11 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I was washed and justified, so I belong.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Forgiveness" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Write your fear. State what you think would happen if people knew your past.
- ☐ Confess and receive. Bring unresolved sin to God and receive forgiveness.
- ☐ Visit a welcoming church. Look for one that talks openly about grace.
- ☐ Tell one safe person. Share your story with a mature believer.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I don't belong in church because of my past": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A step toward welcome
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I don't belong in church because of my past.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, You welcome sinners. Wash me and give me courage to be among Your people. Let my past be a testimony of Your mercy and not a reason to stay away. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

“I have to hide my struggles from other Christians.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

If we have seen others gossiped about, or if our church culture praises victory and quiets doubt, we learn to say “I’m fine.” We fear that sharing a struggle with anxiety, marriage, money, or temptation will cost us respect or leadership. So we smile, pray alone, and hurt in secret.

What Scripture teaches

James writes, “Confess your sins to each other and pray for each other so that you may be healed.” Paul says, “Carry one another’s burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ.” John says, “If we walk in the light as He is in the light, we have fellowship with one another.” Proverbs warns, “He who conceals his sins will not prosper, but whoever confesses and renounces them will find mercy.” Not every person is safe, and wisdom is needed in choosing whom to tell. But God designed healing to happen among His people, not in isolation.

> *“Therefore confess your sins to each other and pray for each other so that you may be healed. The prayer of a righteous man has great power to prevail”* (James 5:16).

Also see

> “Carry one another’s burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ” (Galatians 6:2).

> “But if we walk in the light as He is in the light, we have fellowship with one another, and the blood of Jesus His Son cleanses us from all sin” (1 John 1:7).

> “He who conceals his sins will not prosper, but whoever confesses and renounces them will find mercy” (Proverbs 28:13).

> “And let us consider how to spur one another on to love and good deeds. Let us not neglect meeting together, as some have made a habit, but let us encourage one another, and all the more as you see the Day approaching” (Hebrews 10:24–25).

Common self-statements

- If I tell, they will think less of me.
- Strong Christians do not struggle.
- I have to keep it together.
- They will gossip.
- I have to handle this alone.
- Sharing will cost me my position.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Predicting negative reactions.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I must tell everyone or no one.
- Should statements: Insisting that Christians should not struggle.
- Catastrophizing: Imagining loss of respect and position.

Challenging questions

- What struggle am I hiding, and from whom?
- What has hiding cost me so far?
- Is there one mature, trustworthy believer I could tell?
- What has God designed for confession and prayer?
- What happens to wounds that stay in the dark?
- What would a safe first step look like?

Truth summary

> God made us to carry burdens together. With wise, trustworthy people, I can share my struggles and receive prayer and support. I do not have to handle everything alone, and I do not have to tell everyone.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Confession
- Church
- Friendship
- Sinful Nature
- Help

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Communication

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Broken Things — Matthew West
God can work through imperfect people without waiting for them to become flawless.

Worn — Tenth Avenue North
Weariness can be expressed honestly while asking God for restoration.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I have to hide my struggles from other Christians"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I have to hide my struggles from other Christians." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What am I hiding?
- ☐ What has hiding cost?
- ☐ Who is safe?
- ☐ What will I say?
- ☐ What do I need in response?
- ☐ How will I follow up?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ We are meant to carry burdens together.
- ☐ Confession and prayer lead to healing.
- ☐ Light brings fellowship.
- ☐ Hiding keeps wounds hidden.
- ☐ Safe people exist.
- ☐ I can share wisely.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ James 5:16
  "Therefore confess your sins to each other and pray for each other so that you may be healed. The prayer of a righteous man has great power to prevail."
- ☐ Galatians 6:2
  "Carry one another's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ."
- ☐ 1 John 1:7
  "But if we walk in the light as He is in the light, we have fellowship with one another, and the blood of Jesus His Son cleanses us from all sin."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

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- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
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  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Brought into the light: Each week, record one step in sharing a struggle with a safe person.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, James 5:16 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I can confess and pray with others so that I may be healed.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Confession" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Name the struggle. Write what you are hiding.
- [ ] Choose wisely. Identify one person known for confidentiality and grace.
- [ ] Share briefly. Tell part of it and see how they respond.
- [ ] Ask for prayer. Request regular prayer or check-ins.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I have to hide my struggles from other Christians": _____ % My truth: _____ %

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Sat				
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My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

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My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I have to hide my struggles from other Christians.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have been carrying this alone. Lead me to a wise and trustworthy person with whom I can share. Heal me through Your people, and use my honesty to help others. Amen.

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